



MONTHLY UPDATE

Burundi: monthly update, July 2026

Edition of 2026-08-09 · 16 systems and instruments tracked, 10 of them not held

Developments recorded from artefacts published between 2026-07-01 and 2026-08-09 – July 2026 carried forward to the date of issue, so the report holds the nightly catch to the day it was cut. Sections follow the status report.

Summary of the month

Two things in this period bear on everything else Burundi is building. The regulator [conceded on 3 August 2026 that internet quality is degraded and set out six causes, four of them electricity](#). And an [access-to-information bill was listed on the National Assembly's order paper for the session opened the day before](#), the first dated marker the base holds for it. In between, the consumer association reported that the regulator's [own injunctions on consent had changed nothing](#), the civil-service ministry [published its own list of what its reform has not delivered](#), and the first documented AI-governance workshop was run by an alumni association, not a regulator.

Infrastructure

On 3 August the regulator ARCT [accepted that internet quality is degraded and named the causes](#): recurrent electricity cuts forcing base stations and data centres onto generators the operators struggle to fuel, unstable supply from the utility REGIDESO, bandwidth saturation in urban centres, ageing transmission equipment and simple absence of masts in parts of the country. It said it can apply the sanctions in operators' licence conditions, and named three remedies in train: a draft law enabling ICT infrastructure sharing, a PAFEN-financed mast-deployment programme, and a planned study on powering mobile sites. Lumitel and Econet Leo were contacted for that account and did not respond.

Against the regulator's diagnosis, the consumer association ABUCO [stated on 28 July 2026 that internet package tariffs have more than doubled since the January 2025 instruction to operators to improve service](#), while quality fell. Its president describes the sector as having returned to the situation of the early 2000s and names businesses, traders and public administrations among those affected. The two sources on file attribute that instruction differently, one to the telecommunications ministry and one to the interior minister; no text of it is held.

On the money side, the universal service fund's [revised FY2026/27 procurement plan carries BIF 11.40bn for dedicated IP transit](#) — 8 Mbit to public health facilities and 10 Mbit to schools — funded from the 1% levy on operator turnover rather than from the general budget.

Digital public infrastructure

EAC central bank governors, meeting as the Monetary Affairs Committee, [agreed to accelerate the East African Monetary Union roadmap and welcomed progress on the Regional Cross-Border Payment System Master Plan](#). On their own account the plan's first activities are work plans, priorities and resource mobilisation, so the position is design rather than deployment. The governors also flagged cybersecurity risk to the regional financial system as requiring stronger common measures.

The civil-service ministry [put a set of digitisation claims on the record on 31 July and published the constraints against them](#), which is the more useful half. The programme covers performance evaluation of public agents, a job-classification scheme, an annual costed work plan used across public institutions, progressive interconnection of administrative services, and one-stop service desks. The ministry itself names archive management as still largely manual, service digitisation as unfinished and working tools as insufficient. Citizens interviewed framed digitisation as a distance problem: fewer journeys for people living far from administrative centres.

Governance and regulation

An [access-to-information bill is on the National Assembly's order paper for the session opened at the Kigobe Congress Palace on 3 August 2026](#). The first vice-president listed it among the bills the chamber will examine. Under article 176 of the constitution the Assembly sits in ordinary sessions of three months, putting the outer bound for passage in this sitting at roughly the end of October 2026. No text, tabling number, sponsoring ministry or timetable was published, and no copy is held: the announcement establishes that the bill exists and is scheduled, and nothing about its content. Burundi has had no access-to-information statute on file to date.

On 24 July the consumer association ABUCO [told Iwacu that months of complaints describe subscribers enrolled in paid value-added services without their knowledge and with no notification](#), some losing 3,000 to 10,000 Burundian francs a day; its president says his own statements showed over 40,000 francs taken as such charges across about three months from November 2025. ARCT issued injunctions to Lumitel on 29 May 2026 requiring genuinely voluntary subscription and prior notification; Lumitel maintains nothing activates without a customer's deliberate action; ABUCO reports no significant improvement since, and no sanction is on file. The new data-protection law's central mechanism is consent, and no role for the authority it creates is reported here.

Vietnam's science and technology ministry [received the secretary-general of Burundi's governing party on 28 July 2026 and pressed for faster implementation of the November 2024 memorandum](#). The channel runs through the party rather than the ministry. Vietnam's stated ask was that Burundi create conditions for Lumitel, its own operator's subsidiary, to contribute more; Burundi named postal-system modernisation and internet infrastructure as its priorities. No monetary commitment was announced.

Artificial intelligence and the technology sector

Burundi's first documented AI-governance discussion took place in the professional community rather than in government. A [two-day workshop in Bujumbura on 27 July 2026, organised by the association of Burundian alumni of the German Academic Exchange Service](#), drew doctors, IT specialists, students and developers. The load-bearing statement came from the director-general of the Muganga Innovation Lab: Burundi has recently legislated on

personal-data protection but holds a great deal of information and relatively little of it as structured, consented, usable data — the constraint that makes fairness and traceability arguments premature, and one no AI strategy addresses. Sessions covered AI ethics and labour displacement, AI for resource governance including the MineGuard mining-intelligence platform, UNESCO and ISO frameworks, and data governance for connected devices. AfriPrompt was the other local build named.

Inclusion, capacity and finance

The month's capacity item is bilateral and small. Vietnam reports that what it has delivered under the November 2024 memorandum is [policy transfer rather than build: drafting experience, reference materials supplied to Burundian agencies, 50 desktop computer sets, and Master's scholarships in computer science](#).

On access, ABUCO's [statement of 28 July 2026 on tariffs](#) is the month's one dated position on affordability, and it runs against the service obligations set the previous year. Its proposed remedy is a convening — états généraux bringing public authorities, operators, regulators and consumer organisations into one forum — which is the weakest instrument on the record and the only one a consumer body can reach for.

The research capacity the AI strategy assumes showed itself once in the month, and [outside the state](#).

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